

Somalia



Area 246,200 sq miles (637,657 sq km)
Population 9.6 million
Capital Mogadishu
Currency Somali shilling
Official languages Somali and Arabic
Life expectancy 48 years



The Federal Republic of Somalia was formed when Italian and British territories joined to form an independent nation in 1960. However, since then, Somalia's development has been affected by civil war. Somalia is semiarid and is prone to droughts. As a result, it is heavily dependent on international food aid.

Rwanda



Area 10,169 sq miles (26,338 sq km)
Population 10.9 million
Capital Kigali
Currency Rwandan franc
Official languages French, English, and Kinyarwanda
Life expectancy 46 years



Rwanda lies landlocked in east central Africa. Since independence from France in 1962, ethnic conflict between the Hutu and Tutsi groups has dominated politics. Rwanda is trying to rebuild its war-damaged economy, mainly through tea and coffee exports. It is still dependent on foreign aid.

Angola



Area 481,353 sq miles (1,246,700 sq km)
Population 19.6 million
Capital Luanda
Currency Readjusted Kwanza
Official language Portuguese
Life expectancy 42 years



An oil- and diamond-rich country, Angola has suffered almost continuous civil war since its independence from Portugal in 1975. With hostilities finally ending in 2002, Angola is now on a path to economic recovery. The predominant ethnic groups living here are the Ovimbundu and the Kimbundu.

Kenya



Area 224,962 sq miles (582,650 sq km)
Population 41.6 million
Capital Nairobi
Currency Kenyan shilling
Official languages Kiswahili and English
Life expectancy 53 years



Kenya straddles the equator on Africa's east coast. It gained independence from the UK in 1963. Kenya's capital, Nairobi, is the communications and financial hub for East Africa. Culturally diverse, Kenya has about 70 different ethnic groups. The country's scenic beauty and abundant wildlife have made it a popular tourist destination.

Democratic Republic of Congo



Area 905,568 sq miles (2,345,410 sq km)
Population 67.8 million
Capital Kinshasa
Currency Congolese franc
Official language French
Life expectancy 46 years



Located in east central Africa and formerly known as Zaire, the Democratic Republic of the Congo (DRC) is Africa's second largest country, with vast areas covered by rainforests. Although rich in mineral wealth, it is one of the world's poorest nations due to decades of internal conflicts.

Zambia



Area 290,586 sq miles (752,614 sq km)
Population 13.5 million
Capital Lusaka
Currency Zambian kwacha
Official language English
Life expectancy 42 years



Zambia is a landlocked country in the heart of southern Africa, bordered by the Zambezi River to the south. Tourism is growing, thanks to Zambia's many natural features—including Victoria Falls, one of the Seven Natural Wonders of the World—and a wealth of wildlife.

Uganda



Area 91,133 sq miles (236,040 sq km)
Population 34.5 million
Capital Kampala
Currency Ugandan shilling
Official language English
Life expectancy 51 years



Uganda, an east African country, gained independence from the UK in 1962. It is made up of 13 main ethnic groups, with the largest being the Baganda. Uganda faced many ethnic conflicts in the 1970s and 1980s. Since 1986, President Museveni has ushered in democratic and economic changes, and peace has mostly been restored.



▲ WESTERN LOWLAND GORILLA
Found in the thick rainforests, the endangered western lowland gorilla lives on a vegetarian diet of roots, shoots, and fruit.

Burundi



Area 10,745 sq miles (27,830 sq km)
Population 8.6 million
Capital Bujumbura
Currency Burundian franc
Official languages French and Kirundi
Life expectancy 49 years



Lying just south of the equator, Burundi is a landlocked nation partly bordered by Lake Tanganyika. It suffered a decade of political unrest because of ethnic tension between the Hutu majority and the dominant Tutsi minority. Most of Burundi's people are poor and farm the land to feed themselves.